

THREE LEVELS OF REALITY FOR INNER GUIDANCE

Greetings my very dearest friends who are gathered here and who are blessed indeed. You are not only, by your presence, in the spirit of wanting to receive guidance and truth, but primarily by every single inner effort made toward the realization of your true being. The more this realization is activated, the more blessings are generated from within.

The human being who is cut off from his inner reality is indeed lost. The majority of human beings are more or less totally cut off from it and must therefore find their way back to their inner reality. There are a few who have attained this connection -- and they always were and will be the spiritual leaders of humanity. Every effort on this path is aimed at reestablishing such a connection for inner guidance, for the manifestation of the inner reality.

Jesus Christ has proclaimed that the kingdom of heaven is within man. These words are only too often taken for granted and not much thought is given them. What does it mean when we say "the kingdom?" What does the word "kingdom" symbolize? It symbolizes the absolute power and wealth which the spiritually awakened find to be a reality. We speak, of course, of the spiritual power and wealth of love, truth, peace, expansion, creativity, bliss, and knowledge of the power for the self to create anything it can conceive of. This comprises everything that life could ever be. It means attaining one's full selfhood as it is meant to be. If only you would realize that you have not even attained a particle of the power and beauty, truth and love, ecstasy and possibility of creative expansion which you could possess, execute and which already is yours, my friends! These are not empty words, this is the immediately available truth.

This path toward the inner reality and toward inner guidance is laborious. But it is primarily laborious because you imagine the truth being so far away, so very much farther than it actually is. You cannot conceive of what life already is, right now, and how it could be for you if only you could see it, know it, and therefore realize it. You still perceive this as a faraway, abstract, unreal theory, and you experience yourself as an isolated particle in an essentially hostile universe or, at least, an indifferent universe that has nothing to do with you. You conceive of the universe as a static, immovable fact into which you are put and whose laws have no relationship to your own inner laws.

This concept, and the way you experience yourself in relation to life, is your real difficulty. This is what makes the path so difficult and laborious -- nothing else. Thus the difficulty is not actual; it consists of this concept. The question is how you can change your concept. This is the labor and the effort. And unbelievable as this appears to him who has already attained this reality of being, you struggle against the fulfillment of being your true self as if this were the most horrible fate in the world. If the illusion about the separation between your true being and your momentary consciousness, or the separation between the universe and yourself, would not exist, there would be an instant awakening -- a "click," as it were -- and you would know who you are and what life is.

All my lectures, all our work together attack this problem of your illusion from different angles. All these different approaches have a certain sequential order. Generally, you find the same sequential order within your own, private, personal, individual path. Yet the individual path cannot be forced to imitate the sequence of these lectures. Rather, the process is (as some of you have already found out) that you, with this guiding help, find your own truth as a direct, spontaneous experience from within. Thus this truth usually appears, in the first moments of understanding, so new and fresh that you think you had never heard it before. But afterwards, it can be verified as confirming the lectures you have studied, the lectures which have penetrated the deeper regions of your unconscious. You use the lectures, and then you use your own intuitive faculties, freed progressively more and more by facing the truth you did not want to see in the beginning. Elimination of error frees intuition and creative experience from within. The lectures first give an impetus to this process and later fortify and confirm it when you read them again.

Tonight our specific approach will be to discuss three levels of reality. If you can first comprehend and finally assimilate what I say here, this path will become much easier for you. Some of the illusory difficulty will be eliminated so that your inner guidance will manifest itself as a natural, effortless phenomenon. What are these three levels of reality? You perhaps expect to hear of the well-known levels of the physical, mental, and spiritual realities, about which we have spoken in many different contexts and connections. But this will be something else, so be prepared and gear your mind to a new approach.

The first level of reality is what you think exists. The second level of reality is what actually exists. The third level of reality is what could exist. It is preferable not to discuss this in a philosophical, general, or theoretical manner. The more specific and personal you can be in assimilating what I outline here and the more you can apply it to the seemingly most insignificant, subjective experiences and reactions in your daily struggles, the better it is. Examine your problematic reactions and attitudes, those that do not leave you peaceful, happy and alive, and try to see how what I say tonight applies to you.

No matter how insignificant a disturbance may appear to you or how world-shakingly important, ask yourself, "What do I really believe exists? in me? around me? in the interaction between me and others? in the condition as I experience it?" This is not as easy or simple or self-evident as it may appear offhand -- not at all! I would say to penetrate this level is perhaps the very greatest difficulty. Once this is done, the next two levels of reality will be much easier to deal with. Man is utterly confused about and ignorant of what he really thinks and feels. As a rule he looks away from it and is only vaguely, fuzzily aware of some disturbance, which he quickly rationalizes or seeks such explanations for as seem most fitting, most acceptable, most "logical," or most compatible with his most superficial way of approach to life and himself. Thus he acknowledges only one set of the often many sets of contradiction and conflicting emotions, and even that he does, at best, in a cursory, shallow way. In that way, the true drama of his beliefs and opinions, impressions and reactions, concepts and ideas, hopes and fears is almost entirely obscured. Man takes refuge in collective, oversimplified labels, supposed to express what is really going on in him. When he says he is depressed or anxious or hopeless or angry or hurt or fatigued, he is content to call a host of feelings, impressions, and beliefs by any one of these emotions as though no further search would be required. If he would use the naming of such emotions as a beginning to explore them, it would serve its purpose. But only too often he uses the words of such emotions as a final

explanation. Thus he cannot even attain the first level of reality -- of his often confused and erroneous interpretation of life, of others, and of self. It might sound paradoxical that I call this level reality at all. But it is a temporary reality in that it is what the individual actually happens to feel, think, and believe, whether true or false, while the haze and fog of unspecific awareness is a no man's land and not even a temporary reality. This is why it is so painful and insecure and why in no state could one be more estranged than on this level or "pre-reality," if I may coin this expression.

As you know, it is part of the individual work to painstakingly examine the whys and wherefroms of such collective labels. The first reaction often is that you do not even know why you feel this way and you give yourself a quick and easy answer. Such quick and easy answers may sound exceedingly plausible and serious in a world that shies away from a fresh, new approach. However, every problem needs examining as if it had never existed and as if society hadn't its predigested answers ready.

If one gives some attention to what one really believes causes the specific unhappy feeling -- and usually relatively little attention is required for this -- one finds some answers quite easily. As I mentioned, it is hardly ever just one thing, but contradictory opinions and ideas exist simultaneously. With one set of contradictory ideas, other resulting sets of contradictory reactions, counterreactions, defense measures, further false beliefs, inevitable consequences of those, creating more and more chain reactions, come into being. When all this remains in the fuzzy climate of unawareness, half-awareness, and easy explaining away, how can the first level of reality -- knowing what one thinks exists -- be reached?

For example, it is not at all impossible that a person thinks secretly at one and the same time that he is the most important being in the universe and that he is the least worthy in the universe. Even one such assumption is bound to have innumerable further consequences, breeding further wrong assumptions in one's dealings with the world. Each primary wrong assumption snowballs into a host of untenable, painful, destructive beliefs and defense measures, each in itself causing complicated webs of entanglements and growingly painful beliefs. The two contradictory original assumptions multiply the confusion, entanglements, misconceptions, and the resulting pain. For error is pain, as truth is happiness.

Such mutually exclusive ideas, as well as a host of misconceptions and confusions, are already known to you. Anyone working on such a path knows from experience how burdensome they are and what a relief it is to shed them. They also know that each web of entanglement sets up a special fight against clarifying the confusion in spite of remaining in pain while the confusion lasts, in spite of knowing the liberated, happy state after it is cleared up. Although you all know this, to some degree even out of personal experience and most certainly as a valid theory, none of you are fully aware to what extent you still dwell in the state of pre-reality. Most of my friends do not see in their day to day life where just such a dual concept of the self as at once the highest and the lowest is responsible for that layer of reality where one thinks certain things exist without their necessarily being true.

Also, it is often the case that although you have actually recognized a false assumption, say, about yourself, you still do not follow this through to the further consequences of such an assumption. You fail to see, for example, how this assumption affects your belief about others, what you believe them to be and to think of you, what a situation or incident means in the light of this

assumption about yourself, what certain reactions of the self and of others really mean. If it is pronounced, in so many words, what you believe that this person, situation, or event means, you will then know why you are unhappy in any form. This clear-cut knowing of why you feel the way you do makes a tremendous difference. But not only that, it also gives you the possibility to realize that some of your beliefs are preposterous. You might have, again, admitted this in general and as a theory, but to do so specifically is still extremely hard. Man's intellectual arrogance makes this so difficult. It is arrogant to set oneself up above others, but it is even more damaging to overestimate one's own intellect and thus miss out on one's real inherent wisdom while negating and denying the childish misunderstandings in one's personality. He truly sets himself up above his own state that happens to be true at the moment.

It is so hard to admit what childish nonsense is lodged in the unconscious because this contradicts the concept man has of his intelligence. But perhaps an even greater motivation for keeping the secret beliefs in the haze of vague impressions and feelings rather than acknowledging them precisely is the following. Man has a "vested interest" in keeping these things secret because he feels vaguely that, once out in the open, he is obliged to make changes. He fears to do precisely because he is so committed to his false ideas that a different mode of approach appears a threat to him. But he does not realize that it threatens him only because of the idea in question. The illusory assumptions compound, one leading to another, and they all have to be disentangled in order to bring order and truth into man. If he elevates himself above his own actual self, where his self is still ignorant and misinformed, he cannot establish order. It is hard to admit the utterly childish side with all its senseless ideas and beliefs. The moment this childish side is out in the open, you know it is nonsense, and you are relieved to give up the burdensome beliefs.

In addition to such nonsense, there are also false beliefs and impressions you even consciously assume to be true, at least to some degree. These are even more difficult to handle.

Then there are those beliefs you may sense are somehow false, but you do not wish to alter them. In a way, to assume the painful premise seems preferable to another alternative that appears, deep in your unconscious, even worse. This, too, is of course an illusory assumption, for no truth is ever burdensome, hopeless, or in any way undesirable. The complications and interactions of all the knots, ensnarlements, false beliefs, half-truths, contradictions comprise what actually exists in you. And this must be faced before any further progress can be made.

This level of reality must absolutely be disentangled. If man is unwilling to see what he believes to be true, he cannot ever come to see what is really true at this moment. Consequently, he is unable to reach the third level of reality by changing the present reality -- and not by wishful thinking, illusory magic, or denial of the facts -- into a reality that is more favorable for him.

Let us take an example of general occurrence: man's fear of rejection. The fear of this runs through his psychic life and consequently runs through his outer, physical life. Rejection itself would not be the threat it is for most people if there were no specific assumptions connected with it. What these specific assumptions are has to be unearthed. For example, a person may believe that he is worth nothing, and the rejection is such a great threat only because it seems to confirm the "fact" of his worthlessness. It is thus not sufficient to acknowledge a stereotype "explanation" by saying one feels anxious. It is necessary, first, to acknowledge that the anxiety exists because one fears rejection. Subsequently, it must be unearthed that rejection is so threatening because one feels

worthless and does not wish to admit this feeling. But even this does not go far enough. Now it becomes necessary to find out on what specific grounds the heretofore secret conviction of his worthlessness is based. In other words, all these very specific beliefs and assumptions must be taken out of the fog of vagueness where they hide under the collective label of "anxiety."

When the approach is changed in the fashion suggested here and serious investigation is conducted, when nothing is taken for granted and everything is approached in a new and fresh way, you will find out what you believe exists. From there on, you can begin to look further and begin to question the premises of these beliefs. You can begin to open your eyes and look objectively for what really is. In this transition from one level of reality to the next, you must also ask yourself the question whether you really want to find out, first, what you think exists, and second, what really is. All the false assumptions you harbor seem to dictate that they must be kept secret. For example, should it be true that you actually are worthless and beyond redemption, facing such a fact would indeed be a hard undertaking. But then is it preferable to live a lie by pretending you believe in your worth, while underneath you doubt it? Such considerations will give you the necessary logic to look at what you believe exists in order to then find out what actually exists. The actual truth is that you have a great deal of worth although perhaps in a different way than you believed.

Conversely and simultaneously, you may believe that you are the most important and valuable person on earth, who deserves very special privileges. To ascertain such a belief is difficult because your intellectual knowledge refutes such arrogance and even creates shame. Also, admitting such an idea brings one closer to questioning its validity, which one fears all the more since in the psyche there also lurks the precise opposite extreme -- the assumption of one's worthlessness. If you are not special, then you are nothing. Hence, both assumptions must be kept hidden from consciousness and cannot be examined. Therefore the further chain reactions and compulsive behavior patterns cannot be tested as to their reality value.

So, when you discover that you do not want to find out what exists in you, find out why you do not wish to do so. What false beliefs prevent you from doing so? When you answer that question, you open another little gate that will eventually enable you to change your mind so that you will want to find out (a) what you think exists and (b) what really exists.

In that moment, you are already two important levels closer to the inner guidance and to the inner reality, to the possibility of what could be. This is the kingdom of God inside you. As long as the entanglements of false opinions, of what you believe exists as opposed to what actually exists is not cleared up, you cannot see that even what actually does exist need not be your ultimate state of being. To realize this leads to a tremendously important transition.

The level of what actually does exist is always an enormous relief as compared to what you believe exists. Truth is never, never anywhere near as threatening as the foggy half-truths and evasions, no matter what it is. What you believe exists is a relief as compared to the fog; what actually exists is an even greater relief compared to what you believe exists. The discovery of the manifold possibilities in creation of what could exist is more than liberation. It opens the gates to the world, to the great freedom of cocreation, to unlimited expansion. I might say here that in a mundane psychotherapy, the highest obtainable goal is usually the level of reality, what actually exists. When man accepts this reality, accepts his manifest values and liabilities, accepts the limitations of himself and the outer world, when he copes and deals with this world so as to produce

his best actions and feelings, this would be the ultimate that can be expected under the very best of circumstances. It would be the point at which a patient is successfully dismissed as cured. This is only where our spiritual path begins although, of course, the levels overlap and one cannot say that one must first have completed one level before reaching the next. It never quite works that way. This is why the realization of the third level now and working with it to the best of the present possibility will help the attainment of the lower stages perhaps a bit faster and more painlessly, perhaps a bit more safely and more meaningfully.

As to the third level, what could exist, what actually is -- which is what is usually called the reality -- is not a static condition. It is no more real, true, and unchangeable than the level of what one believes exists. To him who is convinced of it, it seems true and real so that we can speak of his reality at that moment. It is the reality of his assumptions, which lead him to further ideas, with their actual energy and dynamics, with all their consequences that happen in experience and fact. So, what one believes and what is is not so different when one considers the vast stretches of possibilities.

When he assumes that reality is static and immovable, man is as far removed from actual, ultimate reality as he who assumes his illusions to be the final truth. Ultimate reality is essentially flexible and movable. Man is not put into a universe that has its predetermined existence, whose conditions are fixed. Even objects are flux, are condensed energy, constantly moving. The energy is generated by consciousness and by the way it operates. Thus the immovable outer world is a direct product of you and your consciousness. When you can begin to question whether what you found to be reality need be so, you begin to expand the horizon of your concepts, your grasp, and thus it increases your creative power to alter the seemingly static reality. Reality can be expanded for you to the exact degree you wish to expand the horizon, or the frontiers, of your concepts. By concepts, I mean more than the superficial beliefs and theories, of course. When your mind can truly and deeply embrace limitless vistas of experience for happiness and self-expression, this is exactly what your reality must become. For consciousness is explosive, powerful stuff. Each thought, as you know, creates and truly builds your life -- your very own reality circumstances.

However, if the limitless expansion is unconsciously striven for as the child strives for magical omnipotence (because the personality fears and dislikes dealing with the present limitations), it cannot possibly work. It is necessary to first accept the present limitations and cope with them, for they are a product of what the consciousness believes. It is impossible to discover one's own creative power in the positive before one recognizes the connection between negative reality and negative beliefs. Only when you realistically accept the limitation as it is now, can you transcend this limitation in the realization that it does not need to exist. Thus you move into the third level of reality, in which your intellect cannot help you. It is then that the inner guidance can come forth. This inner guidance will be unobstructed when you have moved from the outer level of haze and fog, where you do not know what is going on in you, to the level of what you believe exists, to the level of what actually exists in comparison, and, further, to opening your way into the third level, of what could exist.

Realizing what could exist, the ultimate truth of the inner being, of the real self, is the aim of life itself. For then man has come into his own. The more these levels are transcended, the freer inner guidance becomes, and the more you will comprehend those three levels of reality, which are

man's way of keeping from "being thrown into the outside world" and to coming back home into his inner reality.

What is evil, my friends, all the evil that is so deplored? Evil is all the error, the confusion on the outer hazy level of pre-reality as well as on the level of what one believes exists, which is not even quite conscious so that man is driven into actions and feelings which are truly destructive and are called evil. They blur out the spiritual light of oneness. The existence of evil is the blind drive of not knowing, the vagueness of misbelief, distortion, error. If you truly comprehend these words, my friends, it will be quite impossible for you to ever hate anyone or to believe in the evil nature of certain human beings. You will then see that it is impossible to hate any human being, for such hate is senseless. You can hate the evil of error and the error of evil, you can hate the effect of the error and the vagueness of not knowing what you believe -- or what others believe. That you can hate, but you never hate the person ensnared in the error of not knowing what he believes. That is truly the most alienating state -- not knowing what one believes, assumes, and concludes.

As I indicated before, you must beware of judging yourself or others on having reached any of these levels on the whole. It is always a question of fluctuation and overlapping. An individual may have attained in his development a state of fluctuating between the second and third levels. He may have activated sufficient power from the third level to guide him in all his life expressions. But where he is still trapped in his haze, this guidance does not easily penetrate and cannot be heard.

And now, my dear ones, I am ready for your questions.

QUESTION: What if one doubts that one's needs are justified? Isn't it also a question of what should be?

ANSWER: This is part of the confusion. If you do not know what you are supposed to want, what is a legitimate need on your part, you get confused between the childish aspect that desires unreasonable and unrealizable love and attention, and the adult, legitimate need for human warmth and affection. In this confusion, you may reject yourself for the latter, while, at the same time, you rebel against not obtaining the former. These confusions must all be brought out in the open and examined so that you can put order into them.

In addition to this confusion, there may be confusion about what the other person really feels. Your own confusion inevitably breeds confusion about what exists in the other person. The childish level may conclude you are being rejected since the unrealizable demands are not fulfilled. You may not be able to recognize actual love because it appears in a different way from what you imagined in your present state, in which you may not be able to make room for differences in self-expression. You may also misinterpret the actual rejection as a personal one, and not recognize that this is the manifestation of another person's immaturity and fear of love. All these interactions and mutual currents must be investigated.

The way you can gauge whether you have arrived at what you ought to know about yourself at the moment is the only reliable gauge there is. Do you have the feeling of utter relief and liberation, of being energized and light? If so, you can be absolutely sure that you have attained, at this moment, the level of self-knowledge that you ought to have. When this feeling is missing, you can

be quite sure that there are many answers that are still outstanding and that you need to find. You need to ask yourself the appropriate question.

QUESTION: I am aware of the fact that I distort reality. I wonder how this applies to my job situation, wherein I am caught in a hostility cycle with my boss. At least on my part, I feel very hostile to him. This is very real to me although I know I am overreacting to it. Would you comment upon this?

ANSWER: As you already know, this has really not much to do with your boss. It is all a question between you and your father. You have to ask yourself the relevant questions. What do you really feel about him? What do you believe he felt about you? and why? If you tackle only these three questions, you will already be more in clarity on the level of what you believe exists, rather than being in the fog of not quite knowing what bothers you. Out of these questions, more questions will arise, of course. But let us not hurry ahead; just concentrate on these three questions without taking anything for granted. It is essential that you ask yourself, and answer, these questions. Then you can tackle the next level of considering what is.

For you who heard this lecture, even if you did not always concentrate on my words, something went into your heart, where a seed can grow into a wonderful fruit. Allow this to happen, my friends, for life is so good. The truth is happiness, while unhappiness is always error and misconception. Do not ever forget this. This fact may lead you to have more initiative about discovering the misconceptions of your suffering.

On this day that commemorates the leading faith of this hemisphere, you can perhaps find a special strength in this memory of your forefathers -- not because a special day in itself is of any value of importance as such, but because at times man needs an outer impact or push in order to get something in motion within. For some, religious memories and commemorations may represent such a push. For others, this may not be necessary. They, in turn, may need other reminders and incentives, or another impetus that gives them a motor force with which to find a way out of the entanglements on the outermost level of fog-bound existence which cause so much anxiety and suffering.

Be blessed, my very dearest ones. The love of the universe, the truth and beauty of the universe are within you and around you at all times -- always there, my friends, always. Make yourself see the truth by calling upon the inner guidance so that you and the inner guidance eventually become one. This will happen when you have experienced it sufficiently often as real. Be blessed, be in peace, be in God!

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